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Ultimate Virgin Islands Packing List

2026 Edition • US & British Virgin Islands

The Virgin Islands reward smart packers. Expensive imports, limited store stock, reef protection laws, rocky shorelines, sea urchins, no-see-ums, and relentless Caribbean sun make strategic packing essential. Bring the right gear and you'll save money, stay comfortable, protect the reefs, and enjoy the islands like a local.

■ Sun & Reef Protection

- Reef-safe sunscreen (SPF 30–50+): 2–3 tubes/bottles per person. Top picks: ThinkSport, Badger, Babo Botanicals, or All Good (stick versions travel best).
- Wide-brim UPF 50+ packable sun hat (with chin strap for boat days)
- Polarized UV sunglasses (with strap)
- Rash guards / long-sleeve swim shirts (UPF 50+) — 2 per person
- Lip balm with SPF + after-sun aloe gel
- *Pro Tip:* Apply early and often. A rash guard cuts sunscreen needs dramatically while snorkeling.

■ Snorkeling & Water Gear

- Quality snorkel mask (low-volume, tempered glass) + dry-top snorkel
- Fins (short travel fins recommended for ease)
- Waterproof dry bag (10–20L) — critical for boat charters and beach hopping
- Water shoes or sturdy reef-safe sandals (rocky entries and sea urchins are common)

- Optional: Full-face snorkel mask, GoPro/underwater camera + float strap, mask defogger

■ Clothing & Footwear

- 3–5 swimsuits (quick-dry)
- Lightweight cover-ups, shorts, tank tops, and breezy dresses
- 1–2 pairs light long pants or leggings (evenings, bugs, hikes)
- Light rain jacket or compact poncho
- Comfortable walking sandals with grip + one pair closed-toe shoes for hikes
- One nicer outfit for upscale dinners

■ Health, Bugs & Personal Care

- Strong insect repellent (DEET or high-concentration picaridin)
- Basic first-aid kit: bandages, antiseptic, anti-itch cream, pain reliever, motion sickness tabs, prescriptions
- Hand sanitizer, disinfectant wipes, and small garbage bags
- Reusable water bottle

■ Beach & Boat Day Essentials

- Insulated beach tote or soft cooler
- Quick-dry microfiber beach towel
- Gallon + quart zip-top bags
- Small beach blanket or lightweight ground cover
- Collapsible cooler bag for villa provisioning

■ Electronics & Connectivity

- Portable power bank (10,000–20,000mAh) + waterproof phone pouch
- Chargers + extra adapters
- eSIM or prepaid SIM
- Waterproof action camera + extra batteries/SD cards

■ Food & Grocery Strategy

- Favorite non-perishables: coffee, spices, protein bars, snacks, nuts, condiments
- St. John tip: Stock up at Cost-U-Less on St. Thomas before ferrying over
- Reusable shopping bags and produce bags
- Soft-sided cooler bag for ferry transport

■ Documents & Money

- Valid passport
- Real ID or passport for domestic USVI flights/ferries
- Printed + digital copies of reservations and tickets
- Cash in small bills
- Credit cards

■ What NOT to Bring

- Regular chemical sunscreen
- Heavy luggage or non-quick-dry clothing
- Expensive jewelry or valuables
- Glass bottles
- Single-use plastics
- Spray sunscreen
- Heavy clothing

■ Seasonal & Island-Specific Notes

- Peak Season (Dec–Apr): Prioritize sun protection and light layers for evenings.
- Green/Rainy Season (May–Nov): Stronger bug repellent and quick-dry gear.
- St. John: Extra water shoes and hiking-friendly footwear.
- St. Thomas: More versatile clothing for shopping/dining.
- St. Croix: Strong bug protection and reef shoes for east end beaches.

■ BVI Day Trips: Passport + extra cash for departure tax.

■ Bonus Pro Tips

- Pack in a carry-on whenever possible.
- Use packing cubes for organization.
- Download offline maps and the Virgin Islands National Park app.
- Consider a waterproof wallet for boat days.

In the VI – Honest, practical guidance for the US & British Virgin Islands

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